I was assigned to Juliet Squadron, and became 12188/J/56, Cadet MM Naravane, soon settling down and getting accustomed to the new place and routine. Our other CMs who had been at Khadakwasla from the start helped us in this transition. First-termers are at the bottom of the totem pole and are assigned all sorts of mundane chores, so one learnt the art of becoming as invisible as possible. NDA was also known for its 'ragging' or hazing, which all first-termers had to endure. I had read the book *Battle Cry* by Leon Uris, based on his own experiences of World War II, with the United States Marine Corps. The first part of the book is all about the hazing that newbies undergo and the rigours of Army life. I therefore had a fair idea of what was in store and was mentally prepared for it, knowing that it was a rite of passage. Not everyone was thus prepared. I recollect one of my CMs coming to me about a month into our first term and saying, 'Manoj, I can't take it any more.' I motivated him to hang on and not withdraw from the Academy, and I am glad to say that this person went on to become a Major General (two-star rank) in the Army. There are many views regarding ragging and whether it should be permitted or not. Officially, ragging is banned, and if a junior reports against a senior, it is almost always automatic relegation (for the senior) to the next junior course. Yet ragging goes on of varying intensity depending on the Commandant of the Academy. All I can say is that whatever we underwent helped develop *esprit de corps* among us. Ragging was never degrading but more physical in nature, meant to toughen you up both mentally and physically. It developed a bond between CMs that is lifelong, something our spouses roll their eyes at, as we relive our experiences at course get-togethers. Moreover, we bear no ill-will towards any of our seniors; in fact, they are our best friends.

Copyright @ Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation